THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

Paris Branch: 28 rue des Acacias 75017 PARIS
Tel 01 47 42 19 26
Website: http://www.rblfrance.org/ e-mail: paris@rblfrance.org

Patron:
Her Majesty The Queen
Hon. President:
H.B.M. Ambassador

Incorporated by Royal Charter

NEWSLETTER: FEBRUARY 2016

Chairman's Report

Since the New Year the Paris Branch has lost three stalwart members: Norman Shotton; Committee member Charles-Spencer-Bernard; and just recently Baron Joseph Sigward, ex Free French and noted psycho-analyst and prolific author on his subject. We express our sincere condolences to their families. We plan for our next Newsletter to carry obituaries on each of them. May I appeal here to a close friend or family member of theirs to submit to us their obituary in French or English, with a photograph, so that we may mark appropriately their passing. R.I.P.

Old RBL hands know that there is NO slack season in the annual calendar. Those elected and charged to run your Branch's affairs continue to be solicited from outside parties to appear in this and that ceremony, often beyond our designated Branch area. Such invitations we are bound to decline, but particularly in the Ile-de-France there is on average one invitation a week to have us attend a ceremony with our Standard. Where we can we pass the parcel to another Branch, whose area is closest to the site of the ceremony. Sometimes the ceremony is more appropriate for a RAFA representation, in which case we refer it to our RAF frères d'armes. Sometimes the invitation is temptingly close, such as Normandy, but that region is already designated for the revamped Normandy Calvados Branch. In this context I should like to pay tribute to Paris Branch member Olek Brezicki, who lives in the Eure Département, and who is something of an amateur military historian. His Polish father served as a fighter pilot with the RAF in the Battle of Britain, and he has developed a keen interest in maintaining ceremonies of remembrance in Normandy on sites of Commonwealth and RAF plane-crashes during WWII. He devils the research story behind the crash, attempts to contact the families of the victims, some of them from the far-flung Antipodes and Canada, and organizes a ceremony with the local authorities to receive the families. Bravo Olek, that is very much in the spirit of the RBL, and we are only sorry that we cannot always attend your ceremonies. Incidentally he reports that he receives nothing but the closest of cooperation in his research endeavours from local members of the Souvenir Français. He hopes we can find a way of thanking them to recognize their readiness to help him and therefore the British and Commonwealth airmen. Your Committee will be considering how best we can offer Olek's French colleagues some warm hospitality in our Paris Clubhouse.

Throughout the winter Janet Hadley, our schools project representative on the Branch committee, has continued her diligent work of remaining in contact with the teachers of English-language schools in Ile-de-France and even as far afield as Dijon. She is collecting exhibits from the school-children, in the form of poetry, stories, and music on the theme of Remembrance, and we are actively studying ways of how to exhibit these contributions. This

is a vital part of the RBL function in informing the younger generations of the sacrifices made by their grand-parents' generation, and we are always struck by the impact which history still has on the youngsters, whom we wrinklies tend to write off as cynical and self-centred. Bravo Janet. A valuable contribution to the life of the Paris Branch, and to the children's emotional and civic development

Our new Events Manager, Edouard Plunkett, has taken to his responsibilities like a duck to water, and has already staged interesting ground-breaking events for members to enjoy. We invite readers to consult his contribution to this Newsletter "For your Diary". Our best way to thank Edouard is to support his events whenever we can.

We are delighted to announce that Colonel Oliver Warman, our regular Battlefield visit guide has fully recovered from his medical problems. He was unable to lead us on our visit to Ypres last year, when he was rushed to the operating table the very day that the tour was due to begin. As is well known 2016 is the Centenary Year of the dreadful Battle of the Somme. The battle was planned with our French allies at the Chateau de Chantilly, and was launched on 1st July that year, being designed to distract the Germans from their offensive effort on Verdun in support of our French allies. In the event both battles bled the youth of a whole generation. So it is fitting that our visit this year be to the Somme, where we shall be touring on Saturday 17th and Sunday 18th September. We shall integrate into the itinerary our presence at an official RBL ceremony at midday on the Saturday at the Thiepval Memorial. You will find a Notice of this visit in this Newsletter. Places are limited, so please apply quickly; it will be on a first-come, first-served basis.

To continue the work of the RBL Paris Branch we need to search continuously for new members, especially from the younger generation. It is the job of every member to be alert to the opportunity to invite a friend, neighbour or work colleague to join the Branch. We shall always need new blood and ready hands.

Finally we draw attention to another Notice contained in this Newsletter, on Proxy Voting at our AGMs. Our Overseas Representative on the RBL National Membership Council was surprised to find that our Branch practiced the system of Proxy Voting for resolutions at our AGMs. As we all know this is common practice in 1901 French Associations. It is apparently not practiced in other branches of the RBL, either in the UK or overseas. Threatened with closure of the Branch if we persisted in the practice we were obliged to bow to the request from London. But not readily since we have always regarded the system as a way of recognizing the moral and financial support from loyal members who were never able to attend our meetings through reasons of distance or physical handicap. Closure is not an option for the oldest Branch in the RB.L.

"We will remember them"

For Your Diary

Royal British Legion Events

March – June 2016

Date	Day	Time	Event	Place
9th March	Wednesday	1900hrs	New members and Poppy collectors cocktail	Club House
17th March	Thursday	1230hrs	Monthly Lunch	Club House
TBC April	Wednesday	TBC	Joint Services Dinner	Ecole Militaire
14th April	Thursday	1230hrs	Monthly Lunch	Club House
19th May	Thursday	1230hrs	Monthly Lunch	Club House
16th June	Thursday	1230hrs	Monthly Lunch	Club House

We strongly encourage you all to continue showing your support the RBL Paris Branch by attending these events.

Reservations through reservation@advb.paris

Kind regards,

Ed Plunkett

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

CHRISTMAS TOMBOLA PRIZE LIST RESULTS

NAME	TICKET NO.	PRIZE	TAKEN/NOT TAKEN
S. Jankowski	002558	Pots and Pans	Taken by R. Neave
R. Hallows	001559	Steel Wok	Taken
Djamil Jacir	000931	Writing Set	Taken
Humbert Peridi	000039	Drinks Mats & Receipe Book	Taken
Gerald Aprile	001985	Mystery Gift	Taken
Gregory Caffier	001261	Lunch for 1	Taken
Mariette Peron	000887	Pillow & Candle	Not Taken
Graham Scott	000683	Chocolates	To be given
Edwin Gould	001618	Bottle of Whiskey	To be given
Gisele Corrigan	000453	Lunch for 2	Taken
Fullerton	000235	Spaghetti Set	Taken
Philip Sechet	000665	Bateau Mouche Tickets	Taken
Elizabeth Hallows	001543	Mystery Gift	Taken
Patrick Gautier-Lynham	001689	Hamper	Not Taken
Julie Knapp	002366	Hamper/Foie Gras	Taken
Max Genock	001667	Mystery Prize	Not Taken
Peter Tabori	002359	Brittany Ferries Voucher	Taken
Karin Alton	001980	Glasses	Not Taken
Tony Bennett	001392	Champagne	Taken

Well done to all who won prizes and thank you to all who took part.

HAPPY NEW YEAR TO YOU ALL

SOMME VISIT
Friday 16th - Sunday 18th September 2016

Arrangements have now been completed for our Centenary battlefield visit to the Somme in September 2016. Members of the party will make their own way to and from Arras, where we shall be staying at the Holiday Inn Hotel.

From his experience our guide, Colonel Oliver Warman, late Welsh Guards, considers 20 able-bodied members as the optimum group profile, this being dictated by the logistics of getting on and off our bus and sometimes walking over rough ground. So we have booked 7 double rooms and 6 singles and a 19-seater minibus. From this it will be clear that the tour places will be allocated on a first-come, first-served basis. You are therefore invited to indicate as soon as possible your intention to join the party, by e-mailing the Booking Form attached to: roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr. Nevertheless experience tells us to maintain a waiting list in the event of cancellations, as indeed we shall.

The estimated total cost of the tour package will be 228€ (excluding restaurant meals) for those members taking a single room, and 285€ per couple (excluding restaurant meals) for those occupying a double room. This price includes two nights in the hotel (16th and 17th September), two breakfasts, minibus hire, and a per head contribution to cover our guide's travel and hotel costs. If the party size turns out to be less than 19 there would be a proportionately higher as a result of raising the per head contribution to Oliver's expenses. He charges us no fee as a guide.

Unlike previous tours this time group members will not be asked to pay deposits in advance, but will settle hotel bills individually on check-out on the Sunday morning, The coordinates of the hotel will be circulated later to those who will have booked. Arrangements for settling the Minibus cost @ an estimated 17€ per person (again assuming a full party of 19) will be indicated later, when the exact size of the party is known.

Once bookings have been made and confirmed there will be a cut-off point for any eventual cancellations. The right to cancel the Visit is reserved, since those remaining in the party would see an excessive increase in their share of the fixed costs incurred in covering Oliver's expenses, and it would not then justify Oliver's making the trip. We are therefore obliged to signal that any cancellation received less than 2 weeks before departure (i.e. after 1st May) will involve those cancelling having to pay a penalty equal to their share of those fixed costs had they taken part.

Programme and Booking Form overleaf.

Programme:

Friday 16th September		Check-in at the Holiday Inn, 3, rue du Dr. Brassart, Arras
	8 p.m.	Dinner in nearby restaurant
Saturday 17th September:	9 a.m.	First day of the tour commences in our minibus.
	1 p.m.	Lunch in a café on the hoof.
	8 p.m.	Dinner in nearby restaurant.
Sunday 18th September:	9 a.m.	Second day of the tour commences in our private cars.

Lunch-time: Return to hotel and disperse.

BOOKING FORM

To be returned by e-mail to: roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr. Receipt will then be acknowledged.

First name:…….. Surname……

e-mail: …… Contact telephone: ……..

I wish to participate in the Visit to the Somme on 16th-18th September 2016 . I shall be accompanied by:

First Name: …… Surname: ……

I/we would be interested in having a lift from and to Paris from another party member if possible: YES/NO

I wish to book a Double room/ Single room (delete as appropriate). I understand that I shall settle my hotel/restaurant bill direct to the hotel on checking out. My bill will include a supplement as my contribution to the hotel expenses of our guide. The exact amount of the supplement will be determined two weeks in advance of departure to take into account the size of the party.

I wish to book ….. seats for the two Dinners and two Breakfasts in the Hotel. Fixed menus to be agreed later

Special dietary requirements: ……..

I wish to book …… seats in the Minibus @ estimated 17€ each. Payment arrangements to be indicated later.
I understand a penalty would be charged if I cancelled my reservations less than 14 days before planned departure (1st May). This penalty would represent my contribution to our guide's expenses.

Signed: ……. Date: ……

PROXY VOTING

CONFIDENTIAL NOTICE TO BRANCH MEMBERS

(Pour la version française voir après)

In common with most 1901 Associations in France the Paris Branch of the Royal British Legion has in the past practiced the system of Proxy Voting at our AGM.'s, indeed ever since the Branch AGM adopted this formally in 2001.

Our 2015 AGM, was attended by our Overseas Representative on the London-based Membership Council, Mr Rod Bedford. It came as something of a surprise to hear from him that Proxy voting formed no part of RBL voting procedures neither in the UK nor in any other Overseas Branch. He could not therefore allow us to continue the system, explaining that it had been discouraged throughout the RBL branch network to avoid the obvious danger of its being used to rig elections. This despite the fact that London officials had received minutes of our AGM in the past, and that no comment had been expressed to us by them.

We argued that in the case of the Paris Branch, in the collective memories of the current Branch officers, there had never been any electoral abuse of this kind, Furthermore it had been advocated in 2001 as a means of giving elderly and immobile members both in Paris, and particularly in outlying areas geographically distant from the capital, the opportunity to vote to involve them more closely in the election of Branch officers and other decisions on major strategic issues. It had always been a well-managed procedure and because of our exceptional geographical spread of membership it had always been regarded as a perfectly democratic device in our circumstances.

Mr Bedford had earlier reminded us in email correspondence, following our robustly argued position on the recent Comradeship Project, that if we persisted in resisting London Diktats, he had powers to recommend to the Board of Trustees in London to even close our Branch. This had been done recently in the case of the Normandy & Calvados District Branch against the background of malpractice by senior Branch officers. Your officers did not treat this as an empty threat, but as yet another example of the well-documented insensitive attitudes to overseas branches recently being adopted by London, where anything smacking of democracy has been thrown out of the window. In the face of this real threat we felt that we should not persist in our opposition to Mr Bedford's objection to Proxy voting, and that we should let the matter drop.

We clearly have a duty to report this to our membership as it is a major issue affecting us all. We invite you to address any views you may have on this issue to the Chairman either in a letter addressed to him at the Clubhouse, 28 rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris or in an email to: roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr. He will circulate such correspondence to his fellow officers, and if it is judged by them that there is sufficient case to raise the subject at a motion to be debated at an Extraordinary General Meeting then we would of course call one. If no EGM is to held then there will be a subsequent need to call at least an EGM by correspondence to adopt a resolution to suppress the existing Proxy voting procedure in Paris Branch.

In our relationship with London over the last 12 months your elected officers have been constantly motivated by our perceived primary need to defend the interests of our membership. This was the case with the ill-fated London proposal for our Branch subscriptions to be paid direct to London, and now over Proxy voting.

We will understand any disappointment expressed by you over both the fact and the context of the suppression of Proxy voting, but we are confident that we were right to avoid taking any steps which would lead to the closure of our Branch. The paradox is that we are the oldest Branch of The Royal British Legion, of which fact the National Chairman and Mr Rod Bedford were unaware when they came as our guests to our Annual Committee Dinner in Paris in August. Out of respect to our predecessors we were never going to risk throwing that history out of the window.

Finally you will have noticed that this Notice was headed CONFIDENTIAL , and for obvious reasons we ask you to treat it as such, concerning in particular as it does the views expressed in it on the management shortcomings of London Head Office. So please do not discuss its contents outside the immediate Branch membership.

Roger Thorn
Branch Chairman

LA VOTE PAR PROCURATION

NOTIFICATION CONFIDENTIELLE AUX MEMBRES DE LA RBL PARIS BRANCH

Comme la plupart des associations 1901 en France la Paris Branch de la Royal British Legion a jusqu'alors pratiqué le système de vote par procuration lors de son AGA, ceci depuis son adoption formelle à l'AGA de 2001.

M. Rod Bedford, représentatif de la RBL outre-mer sur le Conseil Général à Londres, était présent à notre AGA de 2015. C'est lui qui nous a surpris avec l'information que la pratique de vote par procuration ne fait pas partie de la procédure de vote RBL ni au Royaume-Uni, ni ailleurs outre-mer. Cette pratique ne devait donc plus continuer. Elle a été supprimée sur l'ensemble de la RBL pour éviter la possibilité de son utilisation pour truquer des élections. Bien que Londres reçoive systématiquement le compte rendu de nos assemblées générales annuelles, jusqu'à là aucun commentaire n'a jamais été exprimé au sujet.

Nous avons fait valoir que dans le cas de la Paris Branch de la RBL, il n'y avait jamais dans la mémoire collective des membres du comité la moindre trace d'abus électorale de ce genre. La pratique avait été préconisée en 2001 comme un moyen de donner aux membres âgés et immobilisés la possibilité de voter, comme pour ceux qui habitent trop loin de la capitale pour assister à des réunions, et ainsi associer davantage nos membres à l'élection du bureau et d'autres décisions stratégiques. La vote par procuration a toujours été une procédure bien gérée, supervisée par notre Président d'honneur ou par notre commissaire aux comptes indépendant de l'association et en l'occurrence la mesure impliquait un nombre assez restreint de nos adhérents. Notamment la

répartition géographique étendue de nos membres (ce qui contraste avec une Branch typique de la RBL au Royaume-Uni) rendait la pratique particulièrement démocratique étant donné nos circonstances particulières.

Déjà M. Bedford nous avait rappelé, dans une correspondance par courriel à la suite de la défense soutenue de notre position concernant l'application du « Comradeship Project », que si nous continuions à résister aux propositions de Londres, il avait le pouvoir de recommander au Conseil d'administration à Londres la fermeture de la RBL Paris Branch. Face à cette menace réelle nous avons estimé que nous ferions mieux de laisser tomber l'affaire. Par conséquent, la possibilité de voter par procuration ne figurera plus dans les papiers que nous envoyons pour notre AGA.

Il était clairement de notre devoir de signaler ces faits à nos membres car il s'agit d'un problème majeur qui nous affecte tous. Si vous souhaitez exprimer vos opinions personnelles sur cette question veuillez, s'il vous plaît, écrire à notre Président, soit dans une lettre adressée à notre siège, au 28 rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris, ou dans un courriel à: roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr. Il fera suivre cette correspondance à l'ensemble du Bureau pour information.

Dans nos rapports avec Londres, en particulier au cours des 12 derniers mois, la première motivation de vos élus a été de défendre les intérêts de nos membres.

Nous allons donc comprendre la déception que vous pouvez ressentir à la fois sur le fait et le contexte de la suppression du vote par procuration, mais nous sommes convaincus d'avoir eu raison à éviter de prendre des mesures qui conduiraient à la fermeture de la Paris Branch de la RBL. Nous sommes après tout la Branch la plus ancienne qui existe de la Royal British Legion et notre respect pour nos prédécesseurs ne nous permettrait jamais de jeter par-dessus bord toute notre histoire en risquant la fermeture de la Paris Branch.

Notre Paris Branch est responsable, respectueuse de la réglementation et sert une fonction vitale dans la vie de la communauté britannique à Paris.

Roger Thorn
President